Umbra: All That Remains Hidden

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General Audiences

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Major Character Death

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Light Hope/Mara (She-Ra)

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Umbra: All That Remains Hidden

by Tempest_Wind

Summary

Mara's hopes, her dreams, her promise led her on the path to becoming Etheria's First Champion. Her courage paved the way for Adora and her friends to change the world. Her sacrifice made their victory tangible. This is her story.

Part 3 of this series focuses on war, instability in the fabric of Etheria, enemies and allies, and the secrets of Mara's greater mission.

This is a prequel story revolving around Mara, the Grayskull Squadron, the origins of the First Ones. This will contain spoilers for the first four seasons of She-Ra. Chapters include links to research done on the original He-Man and She-Ra series.

Notes

This is part 3 in a series.

Read part 1 here: Entropy: All Stars Must Fade.

Read part 2 here: Quintessence: Change is Inevitable.

Eclipse

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mara, as She-Ra, watched as an unfamiliar face flickered into view.

"Mara? It's a pleasure to meet you finally. I'm General Sunder and I'll be giving you your next assignment," his voice was clear to the point of abruptness, like the words landed in Mara's ears before she could process them. He was an older man, his hair graying at the sides with a trimmed moustache above his lips. Despite his military decorations that told a record of service, there was a striking softness to his eyes.

Mara straightened where she stood and hesitated. She awkwardly crossed an arm over her chest before wincing and remembering that was not the right greeting. She bowed her head in confusion. "R-right, General Sunder, sir!" her voice came out too loud to her own ears.

His laughter sounded like relief. "No need to be so formal," he encouraged her. "Or to… do whatever that was. Your team is the first group deployed to this planet that doesn't comprise scientists or the military. Leading such an unusual team must come with a lot of its own unique hurdles."

Mara felt her muscles begin to unclench at the sign of a leader showing sympathy for her. She let herself give in to her own chuckle as the words tumbled freely from her mouth. "Sometimes I wonder if the Council made a *terrible mistake* putting me in charge, I mean, I have *no* qualifications and I don't even know--"

"Mara?" he disrupted her as her ramble became a self-deprecating rant. "The Council doesn't make mistakes," he reminded her.

There came that uneasy twinge as she wondered if somehow she had fooled the Council into believing her competence. “The Council doesn’t make mistakes,” Mara repeated back. “I know… I just wish I could see what they see in me.”

“Well…” he began, eyeing her. “I’m looking at the Champion of Etheria right now: She-Ra. That kind of says a lot, don’t you think?”

Mara looked down at herself, and the faint glow emitting from her skin. “Oh,” she murmured. “Yeah, I… guess you’re right.”

“And the Kingdoms of Bright Moon and Salineas have been brought to balance,” General Sunder went on. “Very good work.”

Tension tightened along Mara’s spine. “General Sunder, about that,” she began. “I know we’re not supposed to give our technology to the Etherians, but this was the only option that seemed to work, a-and the Sea Gate is powered by the Pearl, which is an artefact of Etheria, so really it’s not like we gave them a foreign energy source or… or…”

The general was silent as Mara spoke, and waited until her thought dangled, open-ended before them.

“I haven’t heard anything from the Council to indicate displeasure with your decisions in Bright Moon nor Salineas,” Sunder said. “During the course of your mission to balance Etheria, there will be times where common sense dictates the handling of the situation. It wouldn’t have made sense to let Salineas continue to suffer or to try to relocate the kingdom long-term, so your team found a solution that fixed the problem at its source. I believe that shows resourcefulness, not a need for punishment.”

Nodding along before the words could sink in, Mara waited for a sign or an indication that she’d done wrong. When it didn’t come, she wasn’t sure how to react.

“Oh,” her voice came out very small. “Thank you.”

“But I’m afraid your mission gets more difficult from here,” he said, his tone turning somber. “The Kingdom of Snows and the Kingdom of Scorpion Hill have been in a trade war for the last decade. Their mutual embargo created what seemed to be an uneasy truce. But we’ve received recent reports of open conflict: missing ships and injured civilians that live near Scorpion Hill’s ports.

“Princess Glacia of the Kingdom of Snows has been notoriously difficult to get in contact with,” he went on. “Establish a connection with the Silaxians of the Kingdom of Snows to work towards negotiation. We have chartered a ship for you and your team to travel there and observe along the way for acts of vandalism, piracy, weapons trade, or any other signs of aggression. Report all of your findings back to us.”

Mara nodded along. “This sounds straightforward enough,” she said. “The Grayskull Squadron can definitely handle this.”

The lines on General Sunder’s face tightened as he stared past her. He took a deep breath as though measuring his words.

“Is something…?” Mara began quietly.

“This is our final attempt at peaceful negotiation before we ask for the Primogen Council to seriously consider the use of force.”

Those words echoed in Mara’s ears. “Use of force? With our technology, we would destroy them,” she murmured.

“We don’t want that to be the case,” the general insisted, pain etching into the lines of his face. “But this looming war is a threat to all of Etheria. If the Silaxians cannot be subdued… well, we’re counting on you, Champion of Etheria. Get to the bottom of this situation and report your findings so that we may act.”

The viewscreen blinked out of existence. Despite the warmth of the humming computer and Light Hope’s hologram, Mara felt a chill spread through her bones.

Chapter End Notes

General Sunder is a character from the original She-Ra series. Don’t look him up unless you want spoilers.

I almost named Princess Glacia as “Princess Floe,” but wonderful friends talked me out of that disaster.

Egress

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"They've chartered a ship for us to travel to the Kingdom of Snows, and to observe for any aggressive acts along the way," Mara winced at the way her own voice trembled when telling lies by omission. The temptation to tell the whole truth moved through her like a sneeze, but she fought down the feeling each time. "We leave tonight for the docks in Scorpion Hill."

"How big a ship are we talking?" Lev asked as the group stood in the center of Crystal Castle. "Are there stairs to get to the bunks? And what about the climate at the Kingdom of Snows?" He directed the last question at Gideon.

Mara nodded as she struggled to focus. "Absolutely great questions. We'll go over your mobility concerns after this meeting," she said.

"*No,* you've been awake for two days straight and you look like you're about to drop dead," Serenia interceded. "*You're* going to bed. Lev, Gideon, Nessa, Light Hope and I are going to solve the mobility problems."

"But I'm the leader--" Mara tried to interrupt.

"Shay, make sure Mara gets to bed safely," Serenia said. "If Mara tries to resist, you have my permission to use force."

While Mara knew the term "use force" was probably going to involve stuffed animals being piled on her, the word ran chills through her nerves. She reminded herself that she couldn't dare to tell anyone that if the mission failed, it could become a slaughter.

Mara weakly followed after Shay, too exhausted to drum up either gratitude or frustration for Serenia's bossy nature. There sat a spark inside of her that told her to fight for what she believed in, but she was too tired to know what she believed in anymore.

Shay waited until Mara crawled into bed before they started carrying armfuls of stuffed animals into Mara's room, depositing them haphazardly onto her.

She laughed helplessly. "Okay, okay, your point has been made," she said. Shay gave her a little salute and walked out.

But as silence fell over the room, Mara heard the speaking from down the hall.

"I don't get why we bothered to unpack the ship if we're going to keep living on it," Lev said, his voice coarse with barely-contained frustration. "If they knew we were going to be on the move so much, the Council could have at least told me ahead of time so I could develop tech for it."

"I know, and I agree," Serenia said. "I don't think they prioritized your restrictions, so we're going to do that right now. Let's make a list of all the concerns and maybe Nessa, you can start building a prototype to fit Lev's needs."

"We're going to need to make a materials run before we get on that ship," Nessa said. "We also need to know what kind of ship we're on. I'm thinking magnets to get the scooter to stay in place, and to move it up and down the stairs, but that could wind up messing up the ship's natural pull or any of the instruments involved."

"Pretty funny that the all-seeing, all-knowing Primogen Council can't predict the basic needs of a recruit with limited mobility," Shay spoke up in their usual tone.

"Shay," Nessa hissed. "Light Hope is *right here*."

Mara pressed a stuffed animal to each ear and buried her head under her pillow as she tried to focus on sleep.

A holographic diagram of the ship sat in the center of Crystal Castle's main area. Dr. Modulok's face floated on a viewscreen overlooking the busy room. Light Hope hovered nearby, though her gaze kept darting towards the hall where the sleeping quarters sat. Serenia broke the ship's blueprints apart into segments, as each waking member of the team examined it for issues.

"I am so sorry for the oversight," Dr. Modulok said as the team worked. "We'll get our engineers to make the necessary changes."

"It happens," Lev said with a sigh.

"Yeah, way more often than it should," Shay said as they leaned over their partner to zoom in on a section of the blueprint.

Lev elbowed them in the side. "Not right now," he hissed.

"What? I'm not wrong," Shay insisted.

"The biggest issue I'm seeing is the single staircase that goes to the cabins and bathroom below deck," Nessa said. "If we put a metal slat over it, we can turn it into a ramp--"

"The incline is too steep," Lev said. "I'll have no control and if the ship shifts at all, nothing will stop me from careening downwards."

"A lift of some kind?" Gideon offered.

"It'll need to fold so it doesn't get in the way, but sure," Nessa said. "We can mount it to the railing. It needs to be strong enough to support the weight of the scooter, and has to be secure when it's folded away."

"I'll also need a place to dock my scooter when it's not in use, so it's secure and can recharge," Lev pointed out. "I don't think I'll be able to go above decks much while we're on the water -- the

scooter runs the risk of sliding all over the place if there are any rough patches in the sea."

"Should the docking station be by the staircase?" Dr. Modulok asked as Light Hope glided past his visage.

Lev made a negative sound in his nose. "Though I can make it from the bunks to the staircase on my crutches, the ship isn't a totally still object," he pointed out. "I'm going to fall."

"So the dock should be next to the bed," the scientist conceded.

"I think I'm going to be stuck to the bed for a lot of this trip," Lev muttered. "I'll also need something to stop the scooter from skidding on ice when we arrive..."

"Light Hope?" Serenia's voice stopped the conversation around them as all eyes fell on the hologram who stood flickering by the hallway.

Light Hope looked down at her hand as she tried moving it beyond the boundaries of the room. Upon reaching the hallway, her fingers disappeared.

The AI turned towards them, an unreadable expression on her face. "I am worried for Mara," she said.

"Worried…?" Dr. Modulok repeated, sounding more incredulous than concerned.

Serenia felt something born between pity and shock clench within her. She searched for words a long moment. "Let's let her sleep for now, ok?" she tried to sound gentle as her mind struggled with this new information. "Your hologram can't project that far yet, so one of us will check on her in a little bit."

Chapter End Notes

> Lev's mobility restrictions are something I want to make a point to respect and also bring attention to, since so many

people struggle with that and there's so little representation. I didn't realize I'd also be making a metaphor for that with Light Hope's physical limitations too.

Embarkation

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for the delay. I genuine lost the ability to write this for nearly a week, but now I've built a bit of a buffer and I'm feeling more confident!

Far to the north of the Singing River that ran through the Kingdom of Bright Moon, to the west of the Whispering Woods sat an arid land. Comprising mostly desert with occasional trees scattered throughout, an invisible line divided the Kingdom of Scorpion Hill from its neighbor, the green and thriving Crimson Oasis. Unlike the lands around it, Scorpion Hill was devoid of water and, seemingly, life.

"Are you *sure* this place is supposed to be a kingdom?" Nessa asked, wrinkling her nose as the ship soared through occasional clouds over mounds of sand.

"I'm not entirely sure how to answer that question," Mara said with a careful tone from the captain's seat.

"All my readings said there are active life forms throughout," Gideon offered, moving his holo-screen to give Nessa a better view. "They're all just, you know…" he pointed downwards to illustrate his point.

Nessa's eyebrow twitched in irritation.

Gideon reflexively offered her a smile. "Underground," he added gently.

"I knew what you meant," Nessa snapped. "That was just such a 'Shay' way of presenting information."

"I take full blame for it," Shay said with a grin. "See?" they asked of Lev, who sat slumped at his workstation, holding his head in his hands. "I'm not totally irresponsible."

They hesitated at the ghastly look on Lev's face.

"What's eating you?" Shay asked, leaning over to take a closer peek at Lev's screen. Displayed prominently on it was the desert below them.

"I just… can't believe… there's more *sand, already*," Lev muttered, shaking his head. "I got so caught up with making the ship work, and making changes to my scooter for the ice kingdom, that I forgot my biggest nemesis." He shook his fist at the viewscreen.

Shay tried to offer a sympathetic look, but wry humor twisted at their lips. They slung an arm around their partner's shoulder and clunked heads with him.

"Ow, what the heck was that?" Lev demanded, rubbing his head.

"Won't say -- but if it works, let me know," Shay said.

"What, bashing my head so I don't have to go on this mission?" he replied.

"That might work better, actually," Shay offered.

"Hey Lev, blue sparkly thing up ahead," Serenia said as she guided the ship to stay on path.

"Huh?" Lev yanked his viewscreen up in the direction the ship was headed towards. "Ocean. Oh thank goodness."

"I thought you hate the ocean," Nessa pointed out.

"He liked being carried around by a handsome fish-prince," Shay said and Lev cupped a hand over their mouth.

"Ocean means the ship is near, and if Dr. Modulok kept his word, that ship is ready to accommodate me," Lev said. "Listen, the less time I spend dealing with sand, the better. It gets stuck in the engine on this thing." He patted the scooter's handle.

“Prepare for landing,” Serenia informed the crew and Light Hope, who helped propel the ship down behind the largest dune. Lev made himself comfortable, perched on Gideon’s shoulders as Mara shifted to her alternative form to lift his scooter. The magic that flowed through her was beginning to feel less like an invasive force, and more like the first brisk touch of a cool swimming pool on a hot day.

“What a ragtag group you all are,” came a voice from the docks as they approached. A man with a goatee and a wide smile stood before them, clad in clothing that suited Etheria’s simplistic designs, with long boots for the ocean’s demands.

“We do stick out a bit, I guess,” Mara admitted, lowering Lev’s scooter onto the dock, which pitched to and fro with the weight of it. She winced and darted a sheepish look towards the stranger, who stayed balanced with raised arms as well as brows.

“Well, you’re certainly not the team the Council sends for incognito missions,” he said and held out a hand. “I’m Corporal Romeo. You’ve met General Sunder, my superior officer.”

“Corporal Romeo,” Mara repeated with a faint smile and a relieved sigh. “I’m Mara.” As she looked to the ship, she saw nearly half a dozen purple-skinned people moving around on deck.

“This ship is owned by the Sprite family,” Romeo went on. “They’ll take care of all of your needs.”

As he spoke, the matriarch approached, her long white hair and wide eyes somehow familiar to Mara.

“Well now, dearies, let’s get you onboard,” she said with a gentle smile as Mara felt recognition tighten in her chest.

Excursion

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lev lay on a narrow bed, unable to sit up with the proximity of the bunks stacked above his head. In a room no bigger than a closet, Mara tried to take up as little space as possible while she reviewed the last details with her teammate.

"The tracker application is fully functional now, so if any ships pass nearby, I'll be the first to know it," Lev said.

"Great. Keep track of all movement and if you see anything strange, let us know," Mara said. "If you find anything or need one of us at any time, just message us on the datapads."

"I know, I know," Lev said with a smirk. "You think I don't know how datapads work? I built these things."

"Right," Mara sighed. "I just hate leaving you alone down here."

"You know the minute you venture upstairs you're going to be put to work like the others, right?" Lev pointed out. "Really I'm doing you a favor by letting you hang out down here."

Mara laughed. "I'm not worried about that," she admitted. "I'm more worried about whether Mrs. Sprite has a broom," she said with a steely tone, awkward laughter escaping between her lips.

Lev regarded her with raised brows. "What?"

"No, I--" she began to excuse herself, but stopped. "Nevermind. It… it makes sense, but I can't explain it." She moved to stand, momentarily losing her footing as the ship shifted and swayed. Her head tapped the metal hull and she winced, rubbing at the raw spot.

“Hoo boy, glad I’ll be staying in place for this trip,” Lev said and Mara saw him offer an optimistic smile, despite being trapped in such a tiny space. Resolve tingled its way through her arms and legs: if Lev could try to be positive right now, so could she.

“I’ll be back,” she said and made her way up the stairs. But the door opened on its own and the second-youngest member of the Sprite family came down.

“Oh, sorry,” Mara tried to move out of the way on the narrow staircase.

“Is he down here?” the Twigget asked, her voice softened with shyness.

“Lev? Yeah,” Mara said, also feeling nervousness tinge her words.

“Mom sent me down to play music for him,” the stranger said, then a smile flickered on her lips. “Mom doesn’t like my shanties.”

A chuckle escaped Mara’s lips as she wondered how bad the music was going to be. “Ohhh, I’m sure Lev will love it,” she said with a tight smile as she retreated upstairs.

“Traitor!” Lev shouted from the room.

“Ohhhhhhhhhhhh,” the young girl began, strumming a pleasant note on her small wooden instrument.

Mara closed the door behind herself, sealing away the sound before a voice by her knee jostled her.

“Hi!” cried the youngest child. They stared up at her expectantly with a gap-toothed grin.

“H-hi,” Mara said, smiling down at them.

“Wanna see me do a hand-stand?” they asked in a way where saying “no” was impossible.

“Uhhh-”

“Ms. Mara, you finally came up for air,” the matron said, approaching them. “Sprint, you have plenty more chores to do. Chop-chop!”

The child groaned but made it a point to wave at Mara before leaving. Mara caught herself waving back, and stared at her hand a long moment.

“Everyone on Etheria is so friendly,” Mara said. “I’m jealous that Sprint and the others get to grow up here. I… never made many friends when I was a child.”

Sparkle wore a wizened expression that softened the corners of her face. “Yet you’re surrounded by so much love,” she noted. “Speaking of, how is your teammate, Lev?”

“Oh he’s…” she didn’t want to be rude, “comfortable. The space is very…” she struggled to find a decent way of phrasing it, “quaint.”

Sparkle chuckled. “Space on a seafaring ship is a luxury, not a commodity,” she noted. “You learn to get along very quickly in such tight quarters.” The lines in her face tightened as she spoke. “It becomes a comfort, to have family close when there are pirates on the loose.”

“Pirates,” Mara repeated, her eyes widening. “You’ve had encounters with them before?”

“Ohh yes,” Sparkle said, resting a hand on Mara’s arm. “More often than not, they’re just bullies, taking your goods and scaring you. But sometimes… well, my dear husband would tell you more if he were still with us.”

Mara felt the other woman’s words sink inside of herself. Her hand moved over her mouth as her breath caught in her throat. “I… I’m so sorry,” Mara murmured.

Sparkle patted her arm. “Sadly, that is the cost of this life on the sea,” she said and then indicated for Mara to follow her.

“I… if I may ask, why do you live on the sea? Why not somewhere safer?” she asked as she followed.

“Oh, we lost our home when I was still young,” Sparkle said.

“Your family?” Mara trailed after her.

“No, my people,” she went on. “We lived in the Kingdom of The Whispering Woods until one day the forests turned on us. Made us disoriented, unsafe, and then ejected us.”

Mara froze in place, unable to move forward. Sparkle gave her a painful smile.

“I was once a princess, you know,” she said with a sad smirk.

Chapter End Notes

> My consulting jobs are in crunch time right now. Though I'm trying to make time to write every day, I expect there will be delays. Presently, I'm two chapters ahead of what I post, which is a great pace, but my posting schedule will still be a bit of a mess for November at the least.

Encounter

Chapter Notes

> Election insanity has totally disrupted my writing process, so I'm a little disordered about when I'm posting. I hope this comes at a good time for you, and that this can offer you a meaningful distraction.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You were a princess… of the Whispering Woods," Mara repeated, her fingers tingling with numbness as she stared at the fine lines on the older woman's face.

"That was a long time ago, dearie," the woman said, patting Mara's arm before turning away. "I think I'll put you to work on the tack--"

Mara, acting before she could think, grasped the older woman's arm. "Please," she said before she could think of the right words. "D… does the name Razz sound familiar to you? *Madame* Razz?"

The lines in Sparkle's face shifted to something unreadable, before settling on something distant, nostalgic as her gaze grew glassy, pointed towards the distance.

"Madame Razz? You don't mean Regina, do-?" Sparkle began.

"Captain?"

Mara turned towards the voice, the weight at the end of her hair swinging. "Corporal Romeo?" she met his gaze and felt distinctly that she was in trouble. But Romeo regarded her with genuine curiosity. "Wh-what are you doing on the ship?" she asked as panic coursed through her mind. Did he overhear their conversation?

Was he going to tell the Council what Mara learned?

He stared at her a long moment as if waiting for a punchline. "Er… it was always the intention for me to come along," he said and offered a shrug. "This *is* a scouting mission," he reminded her.

"R-right, right. Right," she said each word as though they had entirely different meanings, before offering him an awkward smile that more closely resembled a wince.

"Lev said a ship will be passing us very soon," he said. As an awkward silence settled between them, Romeo's brows rose. "Did… I interrupt something?"

"Oh, n-no," Mara insisted.

"Just speaking of the past, dearie," Sparkle insisted.

But Romeo's eyes widened and his posture stiffened as he stared past Mara's shoulder. The lines in Sparkle's face deepend as her gaze met the sight in the distance. Numb dread climbed through Mara's arm as a crackling sound met her ears over the rush of water. As she turned, the world seemed to slow, her gaze scanning the endless blue around them until her eyes fell on the source of a glow that tainted the horizon of the pinkish sky.

A skeleton in the shape of a ship sat on the sea, its wood arched like a barren rib cage, orange-red flames engulfing it in a devastating aura. The smell of smoke choked the breath from Mara's lungs, its acrid stench reminding her not of campfire, but of decomposition. There were no sounds of screaming, no cries for help within its charred remains. It floated silently by, guided by the unrelenting ocean towards an absent destination.

A hush fell over the ship that Sparkle called home, all movement on the deck frozen as a dozen sets of eyes took in the destruction before them.

"Pirates," Sparkle was the first to speak, her voice barely above a whisper.

“Pirates did this?” Mara’s voice sounded so small to her own ears. “I thought you said they were just bullies. This… this is…”

“Pirates used to be explorers, not particularly trustworthy folk, but folk you could trust to get you to your destination if the right payment was involved,” Sparkle said. “But lately…” she indicated the ship. “Destruction. They leave no survivors, so none can tell their tale.”

That information didn’t sit well within Mara’s mind. But before she could question it, she caught sight of Romeo’s face. His expression was hardened, indiscernible, but far from surprised.

When he caught sight of Mara, his eyebrows pinched at the edges as an injured frown crossed his lips. “I wish we found them sooner,” he murmured.

“No,” said Sparkle. “Then this ship would have been yet another casualty. We must be on guard as we continue forward.” Her voice was tense, abrupt as she approached her children, quietly directing them down the stairs. Sprint’s worried gaze met Mara’s before they silently followed their siblings to the cabin below.

Mara approached Gideon, who was struggling to tack the sails. She murmured the incantation beneath her breath, transforming into She-Ra before silently taking the rope from him. She nodded in Sparkle’s direction and he gave her a smile through his sorrow, gratitude gleaming.

As Mara tried to use her enhanced strength to capture the windflow, she watched Gideon place a gentle hand on Sparkle’s shoulder. A moment later, the older woman pulled him into a hug as though he was her son. His broad arms encircled her, holding her with a familiarity that resonated beyond experience.

“Gideon’s good with people in a way that I’ll always envy,” Serenia said, approaching Mara. “He just immediately understands everybody around him, and he knows exactly how to comfort them.”

Serenia’s arm rested around the small of Mara’s transformed back. Mara understood that the other woman was seeking comfort, but couldn’t put into words what she needed. Tying down the ropes of the massive sails, she turned to Serenia and held her close.

Serenia’s hands tightened in Mara’s ceremonial garb, shivering faintly as mourning pulled memories to the surface that had long been silent.

Chapter End Notes

> GUESS WHAT MADAME RAZZ HAS A BACKSTORY Y’ALL. Obviously I'm going to diverge from it but ooooh. https://he-man.fandom.com/wiki/Madame_Razz
>
> And also Sea Hawk setting his ships on fire will never have that same vibe again….

Encapsulate

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Corporal Romeo, a word please?” Mara asked, her voice carrying confidence before she shifted back to her normal form. Relieved of the powerful presence of She-Ra, Mara hugged herself and met him with a nervous gaze.

Hours had passed since the haunting sight, though the ghosts of its memory lingered in the minds of those aboard. Downstairs, the Sprite children and their mother made an effort towards merriment, playing music and singing rousing but unfamiliar songs that Lev, Gideon, and Serenia tried to join in on. The sound of their laughter echoed up the stairwell.

“What is it, Captain Mara?” he asked with a smile.

“Oh. Oh, no, n-no way,” she said, holding up her hands. “I-I’m no captain.”

“I’d like to remind you that you *are* captain of the Grayskull Squadron,” he said. “You may not be a military captain, but you’re still a captain, Captain.”

“O-okay,” she murmured, face red as her neck receded towards her shoulders, intent on making herself disappear. “U-um, Corporal, in your report to the Council, I wanted to bring up something important.”

He turned his full attention to her, nodding for her to continue.

“It’s the Whispering Woods,” she began. “They… I’m sure it was a mistake. I’m sure the Council didn’t know that it was an inhabited kingdom.”

Something in Romeo's gaze shifted as recognition moved through his features for a moment before his facial expression was tamped down into something friendly and neutral.

"An inhabited kingdom, you say?" he asked. "Very interesting. Was there a princess of this kingdom?"

Mara's gaze unconsciously darted towards the stairwell.

"I see," Romeo said and Mara winced. "And she told you this?"

A shiver ran through her, and she convinced herself it was the cold sea air. "The Council needs to know that the Whispering Woods were a kingdom," she said. "They'll definitely give it back to the Twiggets when they find out. We'll find a different part of Etheria to carry on our research."

Romeo nodded and after a long moment, he gave Mara an encouraging smile. "Absolutely," he said. "The Council wouldn't have set up in the Whispering Woods if they had any indication that it was so important to the Etherians. I'll make sure to let them know once we return from our trip."

"R-return?" she asked.

"Yes," he said, his tone and manner a little too friendly. "The datapads don't work this far out at sea."

"Oh, Lev found a way to make them communicate to each other," she said. "I'm sure he can find a way to make their signal reach the Council."

Romeo's eyes narrowed, but his brows rose with genuine surprise before he offered her a smile. "That's quite a handy team you have there," he said. "I'll go talk to Lev."

As he exited down the stairs to the warmth below, Mara stood above deck, watching the pink sky shift to purple with the change of the moons. Countless stars dotted the rapidly darkening sky, twinkling from places that were still unexplored, unreachable. The

crisp ocean air danced frozen fingertips along Mara's cheeks as she watched Shay climb up the staircase.

The hacker gave Mara an apprehensive look followed by a shrug. "I think they're writing a three-act musical down there," they said. "I couldn't handle one more shanty."

Mara nodded to them, her head clouded with thoughts of both the past and present. Shay took that as an invitation to stand beside their leader.

"What's eating you?" they asked.

"No, it's…" she looked up at the sky. "I'm trying to find the sun that shines down on Primus."

Shay blinked, nodding slowly as they pressed their lips together. "That's the planet you and Serenia are from, right?" they asked before hesitating. "I mean, your families are from there."

Mara's lips twitched with a faraway smile. "My grandparents used to tell me stories about Primus," she said. "About how blue the grass was and green the sky was. Can you imagine? The water was sweet and flowers grew as tall as people. I… maybe they made some of it up, but I like to believe it's all true."

"Doesn't Serenia know all about that?" Shay asked.

"She was really young," Mara said. "Her family was one of the last to leave after it became uninhabitable. She… doesn't like talking about it, so I don't bring it up."

"Honestly, my family lived planet-side on Eternia for so long, I didn't really believe Primus was a place where people lived until I met you and Serenia," Shay said. "I know I have relatives who were born there, but that was generations ago. To me, it's a planet like any other."

Mara continued to search the stars, as though instinct could guide her to the solar system of her origins. "It's a strange connection,"

she said. “To be honest, it’s not like I would recognize it if I ever went there. And even if it was habitable again, I don’t think I’d live there.” She stared at the scattering of stars, aware now that the odds of picking one in a billion were too low. “The space stations are my home. My *team* is my home. And… in a sense, Etheria is becoming my home too.”

A small smile moved across Mara’s lips as she met Shay’s gaze. Shay watched back, a hint of apprehension mixing with sympathetic sorrow.

“I’ll build you an application so you can find Primus through your datapad,” Shay said.

“Yeah? I’ll hold my datapad up to the sky and it’ll ding when it sees Primus?” she teased.

“Light Hope’s voice will come up and start giving you the history of the planet, but you’ll be so flustered you’ll drop your datapad into the ocean,” they replied.

“*SHAY!*” Mara’s voice cracked as her face flushed.

“I’m not wrong!” they declared.

Chapter End Notes

Getting hints of backstory~

Evaporate

“Mara dearie?” came a voice by her ear and thin fingers by her shoulder.

“R-Razz?” Mara rubbed the sleep from her eyes and moved to sit up, but banged her head on the bunk above her. “Oof…”

“Ooh. Careful, dearie, the beds are narrow,” came that voice as Mara cupped her forehead and cracked an eye open.

“Razz, what are you…?” but as she blinked at the figure below, she saw that it was the matron of the ship.

“It’s Sparkle, dearie,” she said. “We’re arriving shortly.”

Disappointment shifted to trepidation as Mara nodded and slid from under the heavy blanket, climbing down onto the floor. The first thing to strike her was a chill that started deep within and spread to her blood, her muscles, and every nerve in her body. She stood there, shivering.

Sparkle held up a coat for her. “You’re going to need this.”

Mara shivered out an unsteady “Thank you” before wrapping herself tightly in the fur-lined jacket. Though the cold began to leave her skin, it made a home in her bones.

Clad in heavy boots, Mara trudged up the narrow staircase to the deck of the ship. A rainbow of light shone overhead as twinkling snowflakes cascaded down like stardust. Mara exhaled breath she didn’t know she was holding, and the water vapor turned to steam before her.

“I… I didn’t know anything could be this beautiful,” she murmured.

Sparkle raised an eyebrow at her. “Oh, the lights?” she asked, pointing overhead as though this was perfectly casual. “Yes, I

suppose they are quite beautiful the first time."

"I-I mean everything." Mara reached out numb hand and tried to catch the little flakes as they fell, but they dodged her first several attempts. "H-hey!" she called out to the snow. "Stop moving! I want to catch you."

Two flakes that floated the closest to her did not fly away as she slowly moved her hand to cup them. They both immediately turned to water droplets on her skin.

"Oh, no," Mara whispered. "I… I hurt them." She cupped her hand, trying to stop the water from trailing off.

Sparkle peered over at her. "No, my dearie, they just returned to their original form," she said. "They're not hurt."

Mara breathed a sigh of relief. "They just changed form," she murmured. "Right… because snow is really rain, given a different form, isn't it?" As the frozen weather bit her cheeks, she felt them warm with embarrassment over her own overreaction.

"You don't have snow where you come from?" Sparkle asked.

"No, I spent my life on space stations," Mara said. "Temperature-controlled, no real grass or weather or anything. Just recycled air and stars."

Sparkle shook her head. "I can't imagine the life you Eternians experience," she said. "In some ways it sounds as though your technology makes life better, but in other ways, I worry that you're deprived."

Mara felt her heart sink in her chest at that statement. "I-it wasn't a bad life," she insisted. "And I'm here now."

"Yes, and we're nearly at our destination," Sparkle said, pointing ahead towards towering, translucent structures that gleamed in the morning light.

Tension moved through her body as Mara gave a curt nod. “Right,” she murmured. “What’s the estimated arrival time?”

“A little less than two hours until we make port,” she said. “I wanted to give you the first glimpse of what lies ahead. I’ll get started on breakfast while you wake the others.”

It was nice to get orders from someone else, and Mara found herself grateful for Sparkle’s matronly presence. All the competence Mara lacked, Sparkle seemed to make up for, with the added bonus of grace and presence.

As her team set about bundling up for the weather and helping Lev use the lift to bring him up the stairs, Mara moved to the room where the children were clustered, and awoke them as well.

Sprint cracked open their eyes and gazed up at Mara. “Are you all going to be leaving now?”

Mara smiled down at them. “Yes, but we’re going to come right back,” she said.

“Nobody ever comes back from the Kingdom of Snows,” they said.

Spiritina, the eldest, regarded her sibling with a glare. “Sprint, you’re going to scare her!” Mara felt the rush of anxiety clench around her stomach before grabbing at her lungs.

“What? It’s the truth,” Sprint insisted. Then they looked up at Mara with the weight of sadness in their eyes. “I want to see you and your friends again.”

“Well…” Mara breathed, her voice feeling faint. “We’ll just have to return real fast, won’t we?” she replied even as the freezing temperature in her bones grew several degrees colder.

“BREAKFAST!” Sparkle’s voice called from upstairs and Mara jumped, wincing as she hit her head on the ceiling of the small room. She offered the children an awkward smile before shuffling up the stairs after them.

Ephemeral

The palatial expanse of ice towered as tall as it was wide, its translucent structures resting unevenly like spikes piercing through one another. The barren land stood shrouded in layers of a slick glacial surface, suffocating any signs of life beneath a blanket of shimmering crystal. For as beautiful as the snowflakes were, this kingdom stood as a testament to the underlying threat that snow brought.

The below-freezing temperatures bit and snapped at the exposed faces of Mara and her team, leaving their skin painfully tingling and prone to cracking. A deep chill crept into their bones even under their voluminous fur coats and thick boots.

No words were spoken over the howling wind which raked its sharp, icicled claws over their lips and bound their mouths. As Gideon lifted Lev onto his back, the two shivered as a singular unit, while Mara transformed to lift his scooter.

A magical warmth enveloped Mara from within, spreading from her core to the air around her, melting snowflakes long before they could land on her. In place of the chill sat that strange but familiar competence, and an unshakeable feeling that hundreds of eyes were upon her.

Carrying the scooter and walking ahead of the group, Mara led the way down the thin dock, the ice melting half an inch beneath each step she took.

Gideon’s first step onto the frozen dock resulted in him sliding dangerously close to its narrow edge. Lev gripped the other man’s face, a scream stuck in his throat before Gideon managed to regain his balance.

“We’re good, we’re good,” he reassured Lev who, feeling less than confident, tightened his hold around the other man’s neck and

shoulders. Gideon did not want to tell Lev that he was choking away his air supply, and tried to struggle through despite this.

"Hooo, it is *frigid* here," Serenia remarked as she followed close after Gideon, digging her feet into the imprints Mara left behind.

"Yeah, and nobody seems to be around," Nessa pointed out. "But…." her gaze roved along the walls as she left the thought hanging.

"How much are we trusting that Sparkle took us to the right place?" Shay remarked.

"I chose her myself, so I trust her," Romeo tried to assure the team as he followed after them, wrapping his coat more tightly around himself. "This is definitely the right place."

As Mara led the way down the glistening corridor, there came no sounds but their own footsteps, no movement beyond their own shadows. The cold wind howled softly at first through the narrow passage, then crescendoed to a roar.

There came a twinge by her left shoulder and she lowered the scooter onto the ice. Turning to her team, she tried to shake the strange chill that ran like fingernails down her spine.

"I guess no one's here…" she began. "Lev, are you good to--"

Behind you, came a voice that she recognized in her guts, not in her mind, and she turned in time to see a broadsword cut through the air before her.

Mara ducked out of the way, rolling across the icy landscape as that sword swung over her once more. A rain of arrows fell from the sky and her team scattered, rushing to the edges of the corridor.

"HONORED GUESTS," came the battle cry of the swordswoman, her voice projected between wide tusks that extended from her bottom jaw. She stood towering over Mara, the muscles of her

bare, purple arms rippling as cheers and howls echoed around her from above.

Mara, as She-Ra, struggled to unsteady feet as she used her sword for support.

“IT BEGINS,” the swordswoman bellowed.

“Wait, wh--?” Mara cried, freezing to the spot as she watched the sword come down on her.

As if by someone else’s actions, Mara yanked her sword up, knocking the blow out of the way. The swordswoman regarded her with raised brows.

“Wait, I-I don’t know how to fight!” Mara cried.

But the purple swordswoman only roared and struck at Mara again, the tip of her weapon arcing its path towards her neck. Feet that felt too large and foreign on Mara darted nimbly out of the way. Arms that were used to swimming and swinging wielded the Sword of Protection to parry the attack as though it was an extension of her limbs.

“W-why are you doing this?” Mara demanded.

The distinct whistle of arrows rained down once more around her as her approaching team cried out and scattered back towards the ship, the scooter abandoned in the middle of the corridor. The arrows did not let up, continuing to screech and fly as she felt their sharp tips glide past her skin, leaving cuts in their wake. Distracted, she barely avoided another blow from the swordswoman, who aimed a slice towards her waist this time.

“WORTHY ADVERSARY,” the purple-skinned woman hollered, to cheers from above.

“HOW IS THIS FAIR?” Mara shrieked, dodging both arrows and slices as her body moved in a natural, fluid movement that she could not mimic on her best day.

“FIGHT ME!” the swordswoman roared, her sword raised high above her head as she leapt at the Champion. Mara felt cold terror clench within her, but her arms guided her sword.

The swordswoman fell short, arms still as the Sword of Protection rested against the side of her neck.

“Please don’t make me hurt you,” Mara begged, tears sliding down her cheeks.

Esteemed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Please don’t make me hurt you,” Mara begged, tears sliding down her cheeks as the tip of her sword rested against the side of the swordswoman’s neck. Silence fell around them.

Between the tusks of the larger woman, there flickered a grin that was all sharp teeth and menace. Mara braced herself, expecting to be struck by arrows or a swift blow from her sword.

Instead, cheers erupted from above. The swordswoman grasped Mara’s arms in a painfully tight hold, patting her hard enough to leave bruises.

“WORTHY OPPONENT, YOU HAVE DONE WELL!” the swordswoman bellowed as she lifted Mara into a hug, pulling her more than a dozen inches off the ground into a tight embrace, the Sword of Protection hanging limply from an overextended hand.

“Th-thanks,” Mara barely choked out, worried that even the She-Ra form could not stop her bones from being crushed by this woman. “I-I think…”

Ropes flew to the icy floor from above as three-dozen powerful figures slid down to the corridor below. They rushed for Mara’s team, who couldn’t decide between running in terror or submitting to their fate. The ice made the decision for them, preventing their escape as several dozen hands lifted the Grayskull Squadron and Romeo triumphantly into the air.

“What brings you to this kingdom, Honored Adversary?” the swordswoman asked, smiling down at Mara.

“W-we’re here to speak with Princess Glacia,” she said. “Do you know where I can find her?”

The swordswoman broke into a grin. “You’ve already found her!”

Mara hesitated a long moment before the information registered. “Y-YOU? You’re Princess Glacia?”

The warrior princess grinned. “It is customary for all who come to my kingdom to be challenged to battle against me!” she declared. “If they win, they may ask anything of me.”

“A-and if they lose?” Mara asked, her voice trembling.

“Don’t worry about that,” Glacia said. “You are the first to have won in a long, long time! Now is time for CELEBRATION!”

The princess clutched Mara under a powerful arm and dragged her down the hall. Looking back towards her team, the Champion watched as Lev managed to instruct the powerful figures carrying him to move towards his scooter. Arrows littered the perimeter of the vehicle, with several jutting out of the cushion seat.

Lev was placed carefully down beside his mobility aid, his body bent over the object he relied on as he gently removed the arrows. His fingers lingered on the fabric of the seat, puncture marks littering the surface while scratches and dents sat collected on its metal hull. He checked the engine for any signs of damage, but thankfully his scooter booted up without issue, its whirr echoing down the hall.

His two towering carriers made cries of triumph before unceremoniously lifting him onto the shoulders of one muscle-bound woman, all as he protested that his vehicle was fit to drive. Ignoring his pleas, the Silaxian duo worked to carry the scooter together.

Mara and her team were led to the towering obelisk at the end of the long corridor, its precarious structures jutting through one another, frozen by time and weather. Within the bounds of the first glistening room, transparent walls echoed the ghosts of reflections projected hundreds of times into the distance.

They moved deeper into the tower before they were guided to a broad table made of ice, glass, or, more likely, diamonds. With four uneven points, there seemed to be no established "head" of the table, as Princess Glacia grabbed a seemingly random seat and tugged Mara down to sit beside her. Sensing the threat was gone, She-Ra's force slipped back into her sword, leaving Mara a shivering mess at the frozen table.

The Grayskull Squadron and Romeo found themselves deposited haphazardly into mismatched seats before the dozens of clashing chairs were swarmed and claimed without regard for rank or any form of deference. Two herculean women of pink and burnt-orange skin were battling over the last chair. But Lev abandoned his seat to latch onto his scooter as soon as it was placed carelessly down, and he used the vehicle to claim a different spot at the table.

Those members of Glacia's kingdom that didn't have seats, moved down the hall and soon warm, savory smells wafted into the room. Glacia remained silent as she took in the sight of the people before her, all while the Silaxians chatted energetically with strangers as though they were old friends.

"Visitors," Glacia said, her powerful voice softening with affection as her subjects fell silent. "Ah, it has been too long since strangers have basked in the glow of my kingdom." She looked over Mara a long moment, examining the smaller woman's shivering form. "And you can shapeshift. I have TALENTED VISITORS TODAY!"

Glacia's seated warriors gave a triumphant cheer that echoed off of the sleek walls and reverberated through the room, their cries and laughter resounding like waves breaking in the ocean. As if prompted by this cue, several more of Glacia's subjects arose from the kitchen, bringing in piping hot tankards, which Mara and the Grayskull Squadron gratefully accepted.

Mara pressed the warm rim to her frozen lips as she sucked in the scent of unfamiliar spices, and the steam breathed life back into her exposed skin.

Glacia raised her tankard above her head, standing without warning. “TO OUR GUESTS!” she hollered before throwing back her head and drinking the contents of the enormous cup.

Cheers and shouts arose around them as the subjects followed suit with a practiced ease. But as soon as the hot liquid touched Mara’s lips, she gagged and choked. It was the *strongest* alcohol she’d ever encountered in her life, but it was also bitter, painfully sour, and *incredibly spicy*.

She choked, coughing and gagging as she tried to swallow the painful sip, and she listened to the cacophony of her teammates doing the same. Uproarious laughter arose in response and Glacia treated Mara to a painful slap on the back.

“Ah, it’s an acquired taste!” she cried as Mara worried how much this liquid could be melting her own insides. What a price to pay for temporary warmth.

“Now then,” Glacia went on, narrowing her eyes on Mara, “Legendary Princess She-Ra. I’m sure you have many questions.”

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the delay! Two websites I'm building are launching very soon so I'm in crunch time. I hope to pick up with writing this fic again soon, but I'm not sure I can keep up at this time.
>
> If that winds up being the case, I should be able to pick up speed after Thanksgiving (USA).

Exaltation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Legendary Princess She-Ra," Glacia said to Mara. "I'm sure you have many questions."

Mara's eyes widened as the stomach-clench of nerves met the excitable energy of understanding.

"Y-you know who I am?" Mara asked, her voice so soft that it didn't echo off the sleek walls of the crowded room.

"Of course we do!" the princess crowed. "The legendary Protector of Etheria, the spirit of a princess who awakens at times of great strife to bring peace to our humble world."

Mara felt a pang in her chest as she thought of Angella's words: *"I've not heard of a She-Ra before," Angella said. "But I have heard tale of a Protector of Etheria, the spirit of a princess who awakens at times of great disaster and desperate need, to help bring calm, peace, and balance to the world."*

"But you have heard of the name She-Ra?" Mara asked, her voice nearly swallowed by the merrymaking of the boisterous group around her.

Glacia raised an eyebrow as a smirk walked across her lips. Mara's cheeks tinted red, warming despite the frozen temperature.

"When we trade, it is not strictly in material goods," Glacia said. She leaned in closer and Mara watched the other woman's breath fog towards her, the warmth of her presence thawing the frozen weather that bit her skin.

Glacia gestured around herself. "My kingdom is a fortress, separated from the rest of the world," she declared. "We rely on

trade in order to learn about the changes in our world." She tilted her head as she smirked at Mara. "We've heard tale of your compassion in Bright Moon, and your ingenuity in Salineas. And now you may help us ensure that we continue our humble lifestyle in the Kingdom of Snows."

"O-oh, but I--" Mara began but platter after platter arose from the kitchen, various unrecognizable meats resting on hot plates as a variety of root vegetable stews followed thereafter. There was no sense of decorum, no order to the manner by which the subjects piled food onto their plates. Hands were used to grab and rip off drumsticks while battle-worn swords stabbed haphazard slices into the tougher dishes.

Glacia loaded up her plate with more food than Mara had seen in one serving, while she and her team all looked to each other with quiet apprehension.

Shay was the least hesitant to speak up. "Is the food anything like the drink? Because if so I'll pass," they said.

Glacia laughed, her mouth hanging open with half-chewed food as the woman beside the hacker gave them a friendly clap on the back that would have detached their spine if Shay wasn't wearing so many layers.

"I like that bluntness," the princess announced, jabbing a finger in Shay's direction. "You'd make for a decent warrior if you weren't so tiny and fragile."

Shay looked down at themself, momentarily caught off-guard before shrugging. Lev eyed them with a raised brow.

"What?" Shay demanded, a self-conscious feeling tingeing their attempt at indifference.

"I'm trying to picture you wielding a sword," Lev admitted. "I wouldn't exactly call you intimidating."

Shay crossed their arms. “That’s because you’ve never seen me wield a weapon,” they insisted. “Trust me, it’s scary. For the sword. Because I’d be dropping it all the time.”

The Grayskull Squadron couldn’t help the laughter that came in response, and were warmed to hear the delight echoed by the Silaxians around them.

Without hesitation, Glacia picked up Mara’s plate and began piling it high with food. The Grayskull Squadron leader tensed, wanting to say that this was too much, but she couldn’t predict the decorum of this particular group, and so was left in anxious silence.

A plate that could feed five people was placed before her and Mara gave an awkward smile in response, her brows pinched together and her teeth showing too broadly to be sincere. “Th-thanks…” she murmured.

“Now, I’m sure you have questions for me,” Glacia said, folding her hands beneath her chin and smiling fondly.

Mara wanted to start with something small, to test the response of the Silaxians. “Um… I-I take it the cold doesn’t bother you?” Gideon looked up, his eyes alight with interest.

“Silaxian blood is strong,” Glacia insisted, flexing as she spoke. “We are immune to extreme temperatures, and we are all born in peak physical fitness.”

Mara couldn’t help imagining a very buff baby, and she struggled to cover her mouth and hold herself together. Serenia met her gaze, giving her a cautionary look that bordered on exasperation. Meanwhile, Gideon was taking notes.

“But that isn’t the purpose of your visit, is it, Princess?” Glacia asked and Mara felt her face turn red at being addressed this way. Coming from Glacia, it felt more like a pet name than a title. “What answers do you truly seek?”

Mara’s shoulders sunk as she contemplated her mission and the strange but unrelenting kindness of her hosts. She thought of General Sunder’s threat, how the use of force would devastate this precarious kingdom. Like a glacier sinking, Mara couldn’t help imagining this entire civilization collapsing in on itself.

She thought of the skeletal ship floating past, its visage an otherworldly aura of flames. In her mind she recalled Sparkle’s voice: *"Well, my dear husband would tell you more if he were still with us.”*

Mara couldn’t let her anxiety and reverence get the better of her.

“Are you responsible for the pirates that are invading and destroying ships along the Growling Sea?” Mara asked, her voice tight, as silence filtered throughout the room until no sound hung between the two princesses.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for your patience! Chapters may continue to be delayed for a bit as real life has a lot more demands at this time. But I appreciate every one of you for reading and I adore the comments I've been getting. <3

Eruption

"Are you responsible for the pirates that are invading and destroying ships along the Growling Sea?" Mara asked, her voice tight, as silence filtered throughout the room until no sound hung between the two princesses.

The jovial attitude was suffocated from Glacia's expression, as something cold and sharp slid across her face like a knife. As she studied Mara with her gaze, the Champion felt herself caving against the pressure. She wanted to give in, apologize profusely, and pretend this never happened. But for the good of her mission, and for the sake of the Silaxian kingdom, Mara sat up straighter and took a deep, shaking breath as she stared Glacia down.

"We know of the pirates you speak of," the princess said at length, choosing her words carefully. "We've encountered them plenty of times, fought them, lost good people against them. Those pirates are our enemies and we know who sent them."

Mara tensed at this admission, while her team turned towards Glacia, taking in the message. The powerful warriors that sat around them remained silent, their expressions shifting to hardened pain or quiet sorrow. Even Romeo's shoulders began to unclench as he looked around the grieving people clustered in the room.

"Who are they?" Mara asked, her voice hushed.

"They're not pirates at all," the princess said. "They're mercenaries. And every last one of them? They're all Scorpioni."

Mara met Romeo's gaze as tension rippled through the room. She thought of General Sunder's threat, and how this conflict was likely to be resolved through destruction.

"That… that can't be right," Romeo insisted. "The reports said…"

“You know how I said my kingdom relies on trade for more than just goods?” Glacia said, crossing her arms as she leaned back in her seat, a time-weary expression on her face. “The Kingdom of Snows has only one path to the rest of Etheria: through the Valley of the Lost. No one who ventures there returns, so that’s not an option.

“The sea is our only means of connecting to any of the other kingdoms,” she went on. “We wouldn’t do the dishonor of polluting the seas with pirates. We’re a private nation, powerful, but not wholly self-sufficient. The Scorpioni see a weakness in that and target us for it.”

Shivering, Mara considered the other princess’ words a long moment before nodding.

“How long has this conflict with the Scorpioni been happening for?” she asked.

“Generations,” Princess Glacia said. “It spans far beyond a time I can remember.”

“Then what’s changed?” Romeo asked. “The seas were relatively peaceful before now.”

“The weapons changed, and with them, so did the tactics,” Glacia said. “The Scorpioni acquired weapons unlike any we’ve seen in this world. Beams of light that caused massive destruction, and for a time, there were no survivors to tell tale of what happened.”

“Until now,” Nessa pointed out. “What changed?”

Shay quietly tilted their head to the side, brows raised. “You got yourselves some cool new toys in response,” they said.

Glacia’s grin was not kind, and far from pleasant. It was all gritted fangs with a hint of disgust. “They gave us no other options,” she said, a sickened sneer flickering on her lips. “They were destroying our trade, our boats, our people. We were helpless, until an ally stepped in to help.”

“By adding to the destruction with more destruction?” Serenia demanded, her voice louder than Mara was prepared for. Mara met her gaze with a silent plea. “I will *not* hold my tongue over this and *you know why*,” Serenia snapped at her commander.

“WHAT WOULD YOU HAVE DONE?” Glacia’s voice echoed throughout the chamber, sending a chill down Mara’s spine. Her teammates tensed and Romeo looked away. “No other nation cares enough about us to protect us, to fight alongside us. Our relations are built on what they can get from trading with us, not out of interest in our well-being. The moment we stop being useful to the other kingdoms, is the moment we lose everything.”

“You’re guaranteeing devastation and death!” Serenia snapped, rising to her feet.

“SO BE IT!” the princess hollered. “Better mutually assured destruction than giving in quietly. Death before dishonor!” Her people cheered at this statement, rising to their feet as the energy in the room shifted colder.

“You strangers enter my kingdom and judge my people,” Glacia growled, hovering over Mara.

Mara slipped out of her chair, backing away. “N-no, we just don’t want you getting hurt,” she insisted.

“Getting *hurt*?” Glacia spat. “This is WAR. You would rather my people become the unnamed casualties.”

“NO!” Mara cried. “Th-that’s why I’m here! I don’t want you--”

“Get out of my kingdom,” Glacia growled. She stood over Mara, considering for a moment how puny the Champion looked without her magic, and how easy it would be to crush her.

Hands clamped down around Mara, pulling her back as she watched the Princess of Snows drop into her chair, clutching her head in her hands. The Champion and her team were dragged

unceremoniously away while Mara called out for the other princess, begging her to talk.

"Don't let it end this way, *please!*" she shouted as hot tears burned their way down her cheeks.

At the end of the corridor, the Grayskull Squadron and Romeo were thrown into a heap by the docks. Lev's scooter made a sickening creak as it hit the ground, and he crawled over to examine it.

On the bow of the ship, Sparkle watched over them with a sullen expression.

Exiled

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Glacia called them ‘allies,’” Mara pointed out in the cramped quarters as she paced the two feet’s worth of movement that wasn’t taken up by Lev’s recharging scooter.

“How is that significant?” Serenia asked, her tone sullen.

“Given the way she views the other kingdoms, she sees this particular kingdom as trustworthy, maybe even as friends,” she pointed out. “This would have to be a kingdom her people have a lot of interaction with.”

She turned to her team. “Lev, can you trace trade records for the Kingdom of Snows? I want to know who they have the most interactions with.”

“That would be the Kingdom of the Crimson Oasis,” Romeo said before Lev could even look it up. All eyes turned to him. “The Crimson Oasis acts as a wholesaler, buying the bulk of goods from kingdoms and reselling them for a bit of profit. The Crimson Oasis has the most centralized trading posts in all of Etheria.”

“A kingdom that specializes in trade,” Mara repeated to herself. “That would be the most logical ally of the Kingdom of Snows.” There came a burning ache in her chest that refused to reach her chilled bones. A faint ghost of terror arose within her as her mind replayed the moment Glacia kicked them out of her kingdom. But sorrow gripped her as she focused on the look of shame and defeat on Glacia’s face as Mara and the others were dragged away.

Romeo nodded. “I’ll let Sparkle know we’re rerouting our course,” he informed her before disappearing up the stairs.

“I need air,” Serenia announced in a tone that said not to question or follow her. She traced the same cramped route as Romeo as she vanished into the light above.

Mara found herself sitting on the edge of Lev’s bed, her head heavy in her hands as the look of disgust and hatred on Princess Glacia’s face reverberated through her mind. This was followed closely by the outspoken anger and resentment from her team when the truth came out.

With a little effort, Lev poked at his captain with the toe of his boot.

“I want to ask about Serenia’s reaction,” he began. “I mean, we were all upset about the weapons trading, but for Serenia it seemed… personal.”

“That’s not my--” Mara began.

“I know that’s not your information to divulge,” he said. “That’s why I said ‘I wanted to.’”

“It’s preamble,” Shay offered.

“What I’m actually going to say is, go talk to her,” he said.

“I can’t even begin to know what to say,” the words were choked in Mara’s throat. “What if I make it worse?”

“I don’t think you can, unless you don’t go at all,” Lev insisted. “Just show her she’s not alone.”

Her heart felt like lead in her chest, the weight dragging her down with each step she took up the stairs. Midway through, she briefly contemplated giving up, but she pushed past that feeling and carried herself up the rest of the stairs.

Serenia stood near the bow of the ship, staring out at the choppy seas. Mara made no sound as she approached before resting her

cheek on the other woman's shoulder. Serenia's fingers moved through Mara's bangs, toying with them in a silent greeting.

"Sorry I ruined everything," Serenia muttered.

Mara was silent for a long moment as she contemplated her words.

"There was no way for that conversation to go in a positive direction," Mara admitted. "It was doomed from the moment we learned about their weapon trading."

Serenia shoulders tensed beneath her cheek and Mara raised her head to look into the eyes of her best friend.

"I know your feelings towards weapons," the Champion began quietly. "And I've always respected and agreed with it. I just wish I understood the context."

Serenia's shoulders sank as she stared past Mara towards the sea. Mara clutched her hand as she moved to stand beside the other woman, waiting silently for her answer.

"I was barely 9 years old when we were forced out of our homes," Serenia said. "The Eternians had weapons unlike anything we'd seen. There was no defending ourselves. Until then, the few who remained in my little village did everything they could to stay, but we were powerless."

Her hand tightened in Mara's hold and she gripped the woman back as she listened silently, the echo of Mara's heart pounding in her own ears.

"They razed our crops and burned our houses down," Serenia said simply. "That was it. They couldn't scare us into leaving, so they took away everything from us, with weapons that I couldn't comprehend."

Mara was silent a long moment before she whispered, "But Primus had become uninhabitable, right?"

“I guess so,” Serenia muttered. “Sometimes we had to wear masks when going beyond the outskirts of the valley. But my family was determined to stay on our planet. So the Eternians made the decision for us.”

Serenia’s hand tensed on Mara’s before slowly slipping away. She caught sight of tears in her second-in-command’s eyes before Serenia blinked them back.

“I’ve never felt such fear in my entire life,” she said. “And I never want to see someone go through that again. We have to stop this war before more innocent people get caught up in it.”

Chapter End Notes

> If you’re feeling conflicted by the actions of the First Ones, then I did my job right. It’s supposed to leave you wondering if they were trying to do the “right thing.” More shall be revealed over time.

Empathy

Tension rippled through the boat, mimicking the ocean surrounding it. Serenia sequestered herself to the bow of the ship, unable to coax her body or mind into action, and feeling the guilt mount within her with each passing hour. Sprinkle seemed to understand that something significant happened, and so she warned her children against disrupting Serenia.

But the children could sense something was amiss and the youngest two followed Mara closely, creeping after her like a shadow.

"What are you two do-?" she began, but as she turned, they crept further back, whispering and giggling to each other. "Ookay," she murmured, moving forward once more. But she watched from the corner of her eye as they crawled quietly after her.

She slowed her movements and the youngest child, Sprint, bumped into her calf.

"Aha-!" she began a cry of victory until she felt two sets of arms wrap around her legs. "Wh-- whoa!" her arms rushed out, wheeling in a desperate attempt to give her balance as the children clung to her, weighing her down.

The youngsters squealed and grinned up at her as she caught herself enough that a helpless chuckle escaped. "Okay, okay, you win," she said. "Where am I taking you?"

"That way!" the second-youngest, Sprocker, said, pointing towards the staircase.

"Alright, but we're not going below decks like this," Mara announced.

"Awwwww," Sprocker muttered and pouted, but did not argue. Mara was momentarily grateful for Sparkle's unquestionably stern

nature: Mara knew she would have a much harder time saying no to these children.

With enormous effort, she lifted one leg and stepped forward, then the other.

“Hoo, you’re both pretty heavy,” she admitted.

“Turn into that other girl! The tall one!” Sprint insisted.

As ridiculous an idea as this was, and though it was an abuse of these powers granted to her by the Primogen Council, Mara couldn’t help wondering if the spirit of She-Ra would find delight in amusing these children.

Raising her gauntlet, it shifted into a sword and she cried out the words that facilitated her transformation. She felt the magic pulse through her, pulling on her like the weight of the children resting on her feet. As her hair fell free and her armor settled around her, she took in the sight of the delighted faces before moving to walk like this weight was perfectly natural.

With a look of concentration, Nessa climbed up the stairs, before stopping and raising an eyebrow at the laughing trio. It took more than a moment for Mara to realize her teammate was standing there, arms folded and regarding her with the kind of smile that caused the recipient immediate embarrassment.

Mara’s face flushed as she stopped her antics.

“Status report for you, Mara,” Nessa said, moving her hands to her hips.

“Oh y-yes,” Mara straightened where she stood as the two children clung on, refusing to give up their new favorite toy.

“Gideon’s preparing his notes to lecture us on the Lizardfolk of the Crimson Oasis,” Nessa said, rolling her eyes. “He says this one is going to be ‘way more complex than the other kingdoms’ and

then he made that 'Ehhehhehh' sound he makes in the back of his throat when he's nervous."

"Oh…. oh no," Mara murmured.

"Lev is working with Romeo to find out what information we have access to on the Kingdom of the Crimson Oasis' trade deals, what they've recorded and exchanged, and with which parties," Nessa said. "Shay is doing the same thing, but through less legitimate channels."

"I take it you're working with Shay on that?" Mara asked.

"Ahaa, that's cute," Nessa said. "No, I'm giving Shay space to do their work so that we don't throttle each other, while I do a bit of my own digging to see what tools we're going to need to extend our digital range if we're going to keep being on the road like this. I mean, we've barely been in Crystal Castle and it's about time we admit that stability isn't happening yet."

Mara's shoulders sunk. "Light Hope's all alone in that castle…" she murmured.

"Yeah, but she still has access to the ship computer and we can contact her through our datapads," Nessa said, shaking her head as she spoke, her tone giving away her lack of patience. "She's *fine*. Eventually we'll get our orders to do another upgrade and she'll have even more range. It's *fine*, Mara. You worry over nothing."

Mara winced at those last words as they pounded through her mind. Nessa's expression shifted, pinching with pain as she realized her blunder.

"Sorry, I…" Nessa began.

"No, it's okay," Mara said, shielding her feelings with a smile. "I do worry over nothing. It's… it's something I'm working on."

"Right…" the other woman murmured, thrown off by the results of her own insensitivity. "And Serenia's not…?" she began.

"We're giving Serenia a little bit of space right now," Mara said gently but, she hoped, authoritatively.

"Right," Nessa said with a nod. "Well, that's…. everything to report for now. I'm looking forward to Gideon's 3-hour lecture." She turned to go back downstairs, but stopped. Looking over her shoulder, she addressed Mara. "I'll be in the cabin if you need someone."

"Oh, I don't think I'll--" Mara began, but Nessa stopped her with a look.

"We're giving Serenia some space right now, right?" she said, stressing each word. "So *I'll* be *downstairs* if you *need someone*."

Silence passed as Nessa let the words sink in. Mara felt a mix of shame and gratitude clench within her. Even her own teammates knew she needed Serenia for support, to the point where Nessa shed her usual blase attitude to offer Mara assistance. For a moment, Mara felt more like a child than a captain, as she wondered what sort of burden she was for those around her.

"Thank you, Nessa," she murmured.

"No problem," the other woman replied, moving down the stairs.

Estuary

Tension moved through She-Ra's shoulders as she watched the distant mass of sand unfurl into greenery before her. Sparkle's ship veered to the side, past dozens of docks that each held a plethora of boats, while people onboard moved boxes of items with the fluidity of ants marching in a line. The sound of chatter grew closer as the ship slowed its approach, the jovial sounds of trading and bartering created its own music over the crash of ocean waves.

Water lapped at the base of the ship as She-Ra plunged the anchor into the sea below. Sparkle and Romeo cast ropes to the dock, tying the ship in place while Sparkle's two youngest sat on Romeo's shoulders and cheered.

She-Ra carried Lev's scooter past the threshold of the dock into the bustling port. For the sake of the crowd of people bumping into and jostling her, she transformed back into Mara to take up less space, and then immediately disappeared into the wave of people.

"Mara?" she heard Gideon's voice calling for her, and Mara tried raising her arms above her head.

"Heeeere!" she called. "Can you see me?" Even as she tried to make herself more visible, she only became more of a target for the swarm of passersby, who were none too pleased with the space she was taking up. She was relatively certain she overheard someone call her a "country bumpkin" in a derisive tone as fear prickled at the back of her neck.

It felt like she was trapped in a box, surrounded on all sides, her own rapid breathing echoing back to her. She told herself that she was being silly: that Gideon and the others would find her, and that if she moved, surely the sea of people would part for her. But each time she tried to take a step forward, the mass of bodies

veered into her oncoming path, jostling her so that she couldn't move.

This was just people. Why did she feel like she was drowning?

Panting for breath, she looked up. Towering Gideon finally came in sight. The wave of people parted to accommodate him, and he smiled reassuringly down at her.

"Lost you for a second there!" he declared with a smile.

"I guess I got swept up in the crowd," she admitted, trying to sound more confident now that the panic seemed so distant. "There's so many people here…"

"Yeeep," Gideon said with a sigh. "This is the biggest port in Etheria."

"It's *always* like this?" she asked, disbelief tingeing her tone.

"During the daytime hours, yeah," he said as he lowered Lev beside his scooter. "This port has been around for a few decades now, and its location is central to the biggest kingdoms, so it's established itself as a major hub for all of Etheria."

Mara nodded to herself as Lev revved the engine of his scooter and the team moved as one unit, with Gideon at the center, towards the central building. The wooden structure sat at the end of a paved stone walkway.

All down the path stood huts on both sides with Lizardfolk merchants shouting and roaring guttural sounds while holding up their wares. Warehouses sat a little beyond their path, as people of all varieties lugged heavy boxes to and from the ships. Deals were made with rapid hand movements and laughter was exchanged.

"So as I mentioned on the ship, we can't speak the language of the Lizardfolk, but an Etherian Sign Language has been created to

ensure easy communication," Gideon said. "I'm not entirely fluent, but I know enough to act as the interpreter. It *should* be fine."

"I don't like the way he said '*should* be fine,'" said Nessa.

"Real vote of confidence there, Gid," Romeo agreed.

Gideon shook his head. "The Lizardfolk are peaceful merchants," he said. "As soon as we explain the situation, I'm sure it will be fine. What could possibly go wrong?"

--

Night fell over the underground prison as the Grayskull Squadron and Romeo sat clustered in an oversized prison cell. Lev crossed his arms as he lay back on the sand, glaring up at the ceiling. Shay sifted through the dust, picking up rocks and skidding them across the uneven floor.

"*'What could possibly go wrong?'*" Nessa muttered under her breath for the fifth time.

"How was I supposed to know?" Gideon demanded. "All the files said they're a peaceful folk!"

"*Very peaceful*," Nessa muttered. "So peaceful they declared us treasonous and threw us in jail the minute we tried to talk about the weapons to Princess What'sherface--"

"Princess Chamelea," Mara was quick to correct her.

"Whatever," Nessa muttered, flopping back into the sand beside Lev.

"They took my freaking scooter," Lev muttered. Shay stopped throwing rocks, but had nothing of comfort to offer their partner.

"Listen, we can't start biting each other's--" Serenia began.

“It’s ok,” Mara murmured, raising a hand to gently stop Serenia. “We’re all shocked and scared right now. Nobody is at fault, but it’s normal to want to point fingers.”

She looked to Gideon. “It happened so quickly and there was no way you could have prevented this,” she assured him. “And Lev, we *will* get your scooter back, no matter what.”

“Whatever…” he muttered, turning onto his side away from the group.

“We need to be as mad and as scared about it as we can right now, but we can’t turn on each other like this,” Mara said. “They don’t know what datapads are, so we still have a way to communicate with the Primogen Council or Dr. Modulok.”

“Not underground like this,” Nessa said.

“I-I know, but… we’ll find a way,” Mara struggled.

“Just admit we’re toast,” Shay insisted. “The mission went wrong and our so-called all-seeing, all-knowing superiors managed to miss their predictions by a long-shot.”

Romeo raised an eyebrow at this. “You sure turn on them quickly,” he pointed out.

“Maybe I’ve always felt--”

“ENOUGH!” Mara cut through the air with both hands, her voice shaking through the hollowed-out cave they sat in. She squeezed her eyes shut as she tried to swallow back the fear.

“Right now… we only have each other,” Mara said. “And we need to learn how to rely on each other to get through this, okay? Every single one of us needs to put our heads together to come up with a solution, like we have so many times before."

She outstretched her hand to the center. "Team?" she asked, looking each person in the eye.

Slowly, hesitantly, hands reached out to pile on top of hers. The warmth and joy of the bond spread through Mara, and it slowly moved into to the others through the exchange of gentle smiles. As the group felt a sense of strength foster within themselves with this fellowship, the door to the hall slammed open and two armed guards appeared.

"RRR ROARRR RR ERGER ROAR," one guard said and signed with his free hand.

Gideon's eyes widened. "Uh they… they're saying Princess Chamelea demands to speak with Mara, alone." Gideon began signing as he spoke, "I come too? I am interpreter… for Mara."

The guards looked to each other, squinted and nodded. Before Mara could process what was happening, the cell door opened and she and Gideon were being forcefully dragged out.

The last thing she saw was Serenia rushing to her feet, crying out Mara's name. Then the hall door slammed shut.

Earthquake

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Princess Chamelea sat high atop a golden throne, her scaly skin reflecting a royal blue color that shifted to purple as she regarded the unwelcome visitors with a suspicious brow. Mara and Gideon were forced to their knees, bowing before her as she snorted and looked pointedly away.

"Princess, Chamelea, we--" Mara began and Gideon tried signing, but the guards crossed their pudao polearms before their captives, silencing them.

Princess Chamelea gave a grunt, then in a yawning roar growled something in what seemed to be a haughty tone. The Lizardfolk in red and golden robes standing next to her began to sign as the princess rested her head on her chin.

Gideon, vibrating with a mix of nerves and excitement, began translating: "She says 'You dare come to my kingdom and make these dangerous claims?'"

"Off to a good start…" Mara muttered, wishing fervently for Nessa or Shay to be here to make light of the situation.

Gideon went on. "'You claim we have involvement in inciting uh… conflict. Your proof is where?'"

Mara winced visibly as she tried to piece together the flimsy argument. But as Mara cracked open her eyes, she saw Princess Chamelea regard her with what seemed to be a smirk on her reptilian lips.

The burden of her argument sat like a weight in Mara's stomach as she tried to find a way to communicate.

“It… it wasn’t an accusation,” Mara insisted. “We’re looking for a way to stop the violent conflict between the Kingdom of Scorpion Hill and the Kingdom of Snows. Since you trade with both, you may have knowledge regarding their weapons.”

As Gideon finished translating, the princess let out a guttural wheeze that resembled laughter. She held her head, shaking it slightly as her shoulders trembled, her scaly brows pinched with amusement.

The princess growled and once more, her interpreter followed her lead while Gideon translated.

“‘So you come here without proof, demanding answers from my kingdom because we deal in trade,’” Gideon translated and added a personal “sorry” afterwards. “‘What reason does my kingdom have for working with you, stranger?”

Mara steeled herself a long moment as she thought of Princess Glacia’s reaction to her identity. “Because I’m not a stranger on this world,” she said. “If you’ll allow me?” With that question hovering between them, Mara summoned the sword from her gauntlet and felt her body transform with the flow of magic.

The guards standing over her pressed their pudao to her throat, but She-Ra’s raw power prevented the weapons from causing her harm. The bored-looking princess sat up in her chair and regarded She-Ra with a raised brow, her entire demeanor shifting forward in curiosity.

“I assume that since you trade with the other kingdoms, you would have caught wind of the victories of She-Ra,” Mara said through the Champion’s lips as she stood, radiating energy.

The smirk found its way back to Princess Chamelea’s lips as she shifted to a softer pink color.

“‘Word of your accomplishments has reached my kingdom quickly,’” she said through her translators. “‘We’ve heard much about the Princess from another world.”

“Then you’ll understand it’s my duty to try to bring peace and balance to Etheria,” Mara insisted. “Surely you must want to help our mission.”

The princess was silent for a long moment as she contemplated Mara’s offer.

“‘You ask where they get these weapons, yet you don’t seek the source?’” Gideon said for the princess. “‘Do you think you can reason with the weapons, and not the people who make them?’”

“The… the source?” Mara repeated. “The one who’s making the weapons?”

“‘We can get the information you seek, but we’ll need you to do a favor for us first,’” Princess Chamelea went on through Gideon. And then the Princess began to sign on her own, without her interpreter. Gideon went on: “‘There is a fugitive, who fled our kingdom. We need him returned so he may stand trial for his crimes against…. the, uh crown? Against the crown.’”

“I’ll do it,” Mara said. “What is his name?”

“‘He is the last remaining dragon,’” the princess explained. “‘His name is lost to all records. You’ll find him in the Valley of the Lost.’-- Wait, that… that can’t be right.” Gideon broke from translation to question the princess.

She replied with a smug look and Gideon hesitated before translating. “‘Once you have retrieved the prisoner, your team and information will be given to you. Now go’-- wait, your highness--!” Gideon began but the two guards seized him, dragging him back to the cells.

“Gideon!” Mara cried, running after him.

“Don’t give them your name, Mara! Don’t! If you meet a forest elf, don’t tell them anything about you or you’ll--!” but the hall door closed and Gideon’s voice was drowned out.

Mara stood in stunned silence a long moment before one of the guards emerged, staring her down with disinterest. He pointed towards the exit and made a shooing motion at Mara.

Chapter End Notes

> I love all the comments about how Mara doesn't feel so alone in this version because she has her team. Little did you know, I've been planning this from the start.

Empty

Chapter Notes

> Happy New Year, folx! I hope you enjoy this chapter. I've been looking forward to this for soooome tiiiime.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Alone and without a translator, Mara found herself carried as if by the winds from one location to the next. She was in a transport headed towards the Valley of the Lost before she realized that, realistically, She-Ra could have tried to break her team out of the prison. But then what? They would have become fugitives, running and fighting to escape one of the most powerful kingdoms in Etheria.

Fighting was not a productive option, but Mara realized that if she tried standing up for herself and her people more, she might have convinced the princess to let her team join her. Now Mara found herself isolated.

While Sparkle's ship attempted to foster a sense of togetherness, this land-ship was all hot metal and discomfort. Mara was communicated to with gestures that she fought to derive meaning from, as she helped clean and struggled to sleep on a bare mattress.

But as they came to the edge of the Valley, the ship took a sharp turn and left Mara behind in its wake.

The Valley itself seemed at first to be a misnomer, with green hills spanning as far as the eye could see until it stretched out into jagged, white-topped mountains. A fresh breeze blew in a swirling pattern, cool to the touch yet heavy on her skin. The crisp quality of the air reminded Mara of the Kingdom of Snows.

Mara pulled out her datapad to try communicating with General Sunder, but no signal could be carried to this location. It was

though a barrier had been erected against technology, as her datapad glitched and shut down in her hands.

"Figures…" she murmured to herself, as she stared at the array of mountaintops. "I guess I'm doing this alone."

You'll fail, came the voice of doubt from within.

"I can't afford to fail," Mara told herself. "My team is counting on me."

"Who's counting on you?" came a voice from nearby. Mara looked all around, seeking someone at eye-level and finding nothing. When she finally looked down, she jumped with a start.

Barely taller than waist-height stood a tiny girl with long purple pigtails. At first glance, everything about her seemed normal. But as Mara took in each detail separately, they all stood out as jarringly wrong.

Her pinkish skin was several shades too rosy, her mouth was too small to open into a normal smile, and missing from the center of her face was any sign of a nose. As Mara stared into her eyes, she saw a dozen images of herself refracted back from the girl's pupils. A chill ran through her as she finally recognized wings resting on the strange girl's back.

"Who were you talking to?" asked the stranger.

"M-myself," Mara said with a nervous smile. "I talk to myself a lot when I'm scared."

"Don't tell them anything," Gideon had warned her, and now she winced.

"Scaaared?" the girl bared her teeth with a pinched smile, looking strangely endearing despite how wrong her physical arrangement seemed.

Mara took two slow breaths as she tried to steady herself. She offered the girl a patient smile as she tried to quell the anxiety that rose like bile within her.

“Sometimes all of us get scared,” Mara said. “Don’t you?”

The girl giggled. “No way! I’m more scary than anything else out there…” the child’s eyes had a yellowish sheen as she bared pointed teeth in a grin.

In her chest, where Mara’s panic normally sat, existed a void. No emotion bubbled up to clutch her around the throat. Instead, she felt strangely reassured by the presence of this friendly girl.

“Whatcha looking for?” the girl asked, rocking back and forth from her heels to her toes, filled with playful energy.

Mara bent down closer to meet her at eye level. “I’m supposed to meet somebody,” she said. “But I don’t know his name.”

“Ohhhhh…” the girl said. “That’s rough, when you don’t know somebody’s name. Can I have your name?”

Something about that phrasing triggered Gideon’s warning in her head. Though she felt nothing but gentle trust for this girl, she made a promise to Gideon. For a moment, she briefly considered telling the girl that her name was She-Ra, since it wasn’t a lie, but it was too close to the truth.

Mara got down on one knee as she looked into the girl’s compound gaze.

“My friends call me the Champion of Etheria,” Mara said with a soft chuckle.

“Champion?” the child repeated. “That’s so cool! Why do your friends call you that?”

“Well, because it’s my duty to be very brave,” she said, but as the words escaped her lips, she already felt like a failure. What

bravery could she have shown when she was so possessed by fear and cowardice?

"Call me Deena," the girl said and Mara looked up. The last thoughts in Mara's mind disappeared, leaving no trace of their origins. She wondered why she let herself be so bogged down by negative thoughts when this cheerful girl was in her presence.

"Deena? That's a pretty name," Mara said.

"I thought so too!" said Deena. "That's why I took it!"

Mara's thoughts trailed towards something… a promise she made… a feeling she should have, but she couldn't quite remember.

"But my friends call me The Champion of Etheria," Deena said with a grin.

Mara's expression softened. "I've never heard of a Champion of Etheria before," she said, those words never having graced her ears. "What's the job of a Champion of Etheria?"

"It's my duty to be very brave!" Deena cried.

"I think that title suits you very well," Mara said with genuine warmth.

"Thanks! It's *my* title!"

Chapter End Notes

> If you notice, Light Hope refers to Adora as a Champion of Etheria, but she never once refers to Mara by that title in the series. Heeeeeeeeere's whyyyyyyyyyy.

Entice

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Deena guided Mara by the hand down a robust hill towards a cluster of fellow humanoids with butterfly-like wings. A haze of glittering dust filled the air like tiny fireflies come to perch, and Mara caught herself reaching up to gently cup a warm, glowing speck on her fingertip.

Everything within her felt at peace. Each time a stray memory tried to remind her of something grim, beautiful music filled the gaps between her thoughts, severing all connective strands that held together ideas.

The air smelled like freshly-baked honey bread and Deena laughed and squealed as she pulled Mara along to dance with the other children. As she was guided along in a playful circle, her thoughts snagged on her purpose.

What was her purpose?

That was a silly question, her hazy mind consoled her. That was like asking why water was wet. Water just *is*. Mara just *is*. How foolish to waste her time on worrying about doing more than simply existing.

Her body felt lighter than air as Deena hopped along beside Mara, pulling her in a circle that grew faster when the music picked up speed. Laughter escaped Mara's lips as she felt the joy of relief rush through her.

"Why carry the heavy burden of pain?" came voices from around her, or maybe from inside of her. "Life should be about having a good time. When was the last time you let yourself live for the sake of it?"

The soft grass rose to meet her, as she rested painlessly on the ground. Warm, fresh bread was placed in her hand, which she mindlessly brought to her lips as a dozen faces surrounded her, staring down at her with their compound pupils. Their gazes glowed yellow not unlike the flakes of light falling like snow around her. Their grins revealed razor-sharp teeth that Mara watched with total peace, her fear a distant memory.

"Mara…" came a voice she recognized. Who was saying that?

"Mara, you have forgotten your purpose," the voice carried on.

"No… I don't want a purpose…" she mumbled aloud.

Deena's smile slipped, her insectoid gaze darting around with confusion. "This one isn't…" she began.

Mara's body was consumed by a white glow and she stiffened as she felt magic rush through her like blood through her veins.

"I will not allow the protector of Etheria to lose her purpose," the voice declared, and Mara recognized it as her own voice, being used by another.

Her body elongated and the creatures around her stumbled back. Her hair freed itself from her braid, lightening and cascading to the grass around her while the magic rushing through her freed her from the depths of the fog in her mind.

She-Ra rose to her feet, her threatening aura extending out around her as her glowing eyes focused their rage on Deena.

The creature known as Deena shuddered and backed away, raising her hands as if to protect herself. "I-I didn't--" she began.

She-Ra's sword was against her throat. "**You forest elves took something from me,**" she growled. "Give me back my memories."

"They're there! We just… made them quiet," Deena insisted.

As She-Ra clutched her head and focused, the first traces of memories were pulled to the surface: Gideon's warnings, followed by the knowledge of her team, as well as her mission.

She-Ra's gaze darted to Deena's eyes and she glared. "You took something else," she growled. "I don't know what."

"I-I can't give that back," Deena admitted. "Now that it's mine, you never had it. I can't give it back."

She-Ra's enormous hand grabbed the front of tiny Deena's dress as she lifted the diminutive girl into the air.

A blast of magic struck She-Ra in the side and she winced, staggering. Deena cried out and went to hide behind another of her kind. Anger pulsing within her, She-Ra drew her sword, as Mara's faint cry for her to stop went unnoticed.

"I won't let you take my purpose from me. I'm going to find the last dragon and bring Etheria to balance," She-Ra cried, swiping at the figure who launched the magical attack at her.

She was surrounded on all sides by these insectoid creatures, who became less reminiscent to humans the longer She-Ra stared at them. She raised her sword with confidence and ran to the nearest figure, intent upon a deadly blow.

"NOOO!" cried Mara, from inside her own body.

"Wait!" came that high-pitched voice, and She-Ra stopped short as the forest elf before her faltered and covered his face with an arm, trembling with fear. Dread climbed through She-Ra's magical form as Mara wondered at how quickly these creatures would have fallen if not for the intercession.

Deena approached, her arms outstretched. Fear mixed with determination sat pinched on her face.

"You're seeking the last dragon? I know where he is," she said.

“How am I supposed to trust you?” She-Ra ground out.

“He needs help,” Deena pleaded. “He’s sick, and fading. Your magic might be the only thing that can stop him from getting worse. And… honestly, what other options do you have?”

Chapter End Notes

Forest elves are the race that the butterfly-like people in Elberron are. I decided to make their ancestors far more fae-like.

Extraordinary

Deena approached, holding her hand up towards She-Ra. Staring into the girl's fractionated gaze, Mara couldn't help the twinge of sympathy that arose within. A force beyond her control tensed as if in warning.

Do not fall victim to their tricks, arose that voice from within.

"I want to try believing her," Mara insisted. *"I don't think she's lying."*

Then I leave our fate in your hands, She-Ra said.

The force of She-Ra began to recede as Mara felt herself taking control from within this form. She blinked into awareness of her own magically modified body, raising her hands and staring at them as she opened and closed her fingers of her own volition.

Deena watched her with interest, curiously gleaming in her fractionated gaze. Mara, as She-Ra, couldn't help a soft smile in return before taking the girl's hand.

They moved away from the nervous crowd as Mara bowed her head sheepishly in guilt.

"S-sorry about earlier…" she tried calling over her shoulder, but discussions broke out among the forest elves as Deena tugged her towards a lush hilltop.

The diminutive girl's broad wings fluttered with the rattle of paper as she easily soared to the top of the hill. Mara struggled to keep up, finding the ground less predictable than expected. Her shoes slipped as though moving through mud or sand, while the grass seemed unruffled by her presence.

Yet as she walked up the hill, she found the ground slanting and becoming steeper beneath her feet. Where the crest of the hilltop

should have been, there was more hill. Frustrated, Mara began grabbing at tufts of grass to help her climb the tilting earth.

"You're a strange one," Deena remarked. "Why don't you use your magic to climb?"

"M… magic to climb?" Mara asked as she panted for air. "I… I don't think that's how this works."

"Sure it is!" Deena said. "I mean, look at me. I can climb this hill no problem." She fluttered up to rest at the top of the hill as it grew further away from Mara with each careful step. "We're made of the same magic."

"I-I don't think we are though," Mara said, digging her fingertips into the dirt as she felt her legs struggle to stay close to the hill that more distinctly resembled a cliff now.

Deena squinted at her. "Uh-uh," she said with a playful giggle. "Your magic is the same as what we have here in the Valley. We're made of the same stuff, princess…"

"Princess…?" Mara clung to the grassy cliffside, struggling to hold on. "You… you know who I am?"

The forest elf tilted her head with interest, like a cat watching a bug. She spoke up in a sing-song voice: "Interesting. A creature from another world thinks she can play dress-up as an Etherian princess."

Mara winced, as she felt the ground shift, tilting her further back. The sky became indistinguishable from the ground as she stared into the fractured gaze of Deena.

"I am… *not* playing dress-up," Mara insisted as she felt her legs dangle away from the cliffside, her stomach and head twisting as they fought to find their way upright, like being lost deep underwater. "I am Mara… I… I *am* She-Ra. And I'm going to balance Etheria!"

She felt the magic solidify inside of her, uniting with her bones and blood as though they were made of the same substance. Instead of being shaped and changed by the force of this power, she felt her body generate its magic, starting from within the parts of her that were still distinctly Mara: her heart and her mind.

Mara's hand grasped the dirt and grass, pulling it away like a sheet, revealing the icy mountain beneath. Her freezing hands dug into a jagged cliffside as snow pelted her from above. Wind screamed in her ears as Mara pulled herself further upwards, the illusory greenery around her fading like an old memory.

"My friend must be *really* important for balancing Etheria," Deena said over the roar of the wind.

"He…" Mara hesitated, sensing that giving away the truth of the dragon's fate would result in more endless misdirecting. "I think he is. What can you tell me about him? The records say his name was lost a while ago."

"Mmhmm," Deena said with a nod. "He's been in the Valley for a long, long time."

Mara struggled, feeling her feet slip against ice. Grasping her sword in her hand, it twisted itself into rope that she effortlessly lassoed onto a jagged surface.

"Have you known him long?" Mara asked through gritted teeth as she pulled herself up the mountainside.

"Ohhhhh, yes, I'm much older than I look," Deena gave a smile that was all pointy teeth as she fluttered easily ahead of Mara's path. "I'm the first friend Sorrowful made here!"

"S-Sorrowful?" Mara asked as the wind whipped and snow pelted her.

"Yep! That's what I named him after he forgot his own name," she said with ease. "People forget things so easily around these parts. But that's okay: I gave him a new name."

The chill running down Mara’s spine wasn’t from the weather alone.

“A-and why did you name him Sorrowful?” Mara asked.

Deena gave her a curious expression. “Wouldn’t you be sorrowful, if you were the last of your kind?”

Explore

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Wind howling as it whipped against her, Mara climbed the next few steps up the steep mountainside. Flames made of a barren chill licked at her ankles and spread feelings of isolation and coldness down to her bones. Icicles in the shape of thunder cracked in the sky before raining sleet below. Deena seemed untouched even as the mountain grew more slippery.

“What’s your real reason for seeking my friend?” Dina asked, tilting her head as though the weather was a mere afterthought.

“I… I need to speak to him… to save my friends,” Mara said.

“Ohhhhh Sorrowful isn’t going to be able to help much,” Deena insisted. “He doesn’t have any adventure left in him.”

“What about… what about memories of adventures?” Mara caught herself asking.

“Those are gone too,” Deena said. “Those memories were hurting him, so I gave them to myself as a gift. They were delicious!”

Mara’s grip tightened on her rope as her stomach clenched. She thought of the moment she almost gave in to the forest elves, how peaceful it all felt, how willing she was to depart from everything painful that bound her to this world.

And then she thought of all the people she would have left behind, abandoned: her team whose fates would be sealed in that cell in the desert, the Primogen Council who hand-picked her as She-Ra’s mantle, and the Etherians themselves, who would have suffered endless disasters as their world became more and more unstable.

“I almost forgot everything…” Mara caught herself murmuring. The blue crystal in her transformed sword glistened with the next strike of icicle-thunder.

“Yeahhh, you looked so peaceful and cozy,” Deena said. “You looked really happy. Not like you do now. Now you look all *sad* and *serious.*”

Shivering, Mara felt the pulse of anger from deep inside. She recalled the same sensation as she stood at Salineas’ gate, the hands of her body burning as she desperately begged She-Ra to let go. This same righteous fury that She-Ra used to suppress her, now came boiling to the surface.

Please let me do this, Mara said within her mind.

”Do not disappoint me,” the magic within her bones replied.

“Deena,” Mara began gently, “earlier, when you brought me to your people, you weren’t trying to hurt me, right?”

“Hurt you?” Deena asked, tilting her head. “No, silly! We were trying to take away your hurt! You carry pain on your shoulders like a bag full of bricks.”

“Th-that’s true,” Mara said with a wince as icicle lightning crashed overhead. “You were trying to take away my pain and anxiety, right?”

“Yup!”

Mara gave her a pained smile. “And you’ve been trying to take away Sorrowful’s pain too, right?”

“Youuuuu got it!” Deena said.

“You’re a good friend, Deena,” Mara said softly. “You really care about making your friends happy.”

The lightning stopped, the snow ceased falling, and Mara found it easier to get a solid footing on the sloping mountaintop. Deena stared down at her with her insectoid gaze.

“I am a good friend,” Deena said, her voice tense and heavy.

“You are,” Mara insisted. “But sometimes, your friends carry their pain on purpose. If you take away their pain, that can make them very sad too.”

“No!” Deena snapped. “No! I make them happy! I make people happy!”

“You do,” Mara insisted quietly. “But if I had disappeared without completing my mission, that would be a very sad thing for all the people I’ve left behind. And I would have been very sad to learn that I couldn’t help my friends or save this world. Even though I couldn’t feel pain, it still would have made me sad.”

“No, no, NO!” Deena covered her elf-like ears.

The mountaintop shifted at an angle so that it laid flat and Mara found herself walking across it like it was craggy ground. She approached Deena and gently petted the forest elf’s hands.

“As a friend, it isn’t your job to take away the pain of others,” Mara said. “In fact, I’d prefer it if you kept me company when I’m struggling instead. Knowing I’m not alone helps me more than I can put into words.”

Deena looked up at her, the pain fractured throughout her gaze.

“If you accept me the way that I am, flaws and everything, then that gives me a happiness that no magic can mimic,” Mara said as Deena slowly lowered her hands.

“Why would you want to live with such pain in your mind?” Deena asked quietly.

“Because pain can be a lot of things,” Mara said. “I feel pain for someone else who is struggling. I feel pain because my duty is important and people are counting on me. I feel pain because I’m scared, but I know what I have to do. Pain in my mind sometimes is unnecessary, but sometimes it means that I’m dealing with something incredibly important.”

“And you want to keep that pain?” Deena said.

“Yeah, I’d like to.”

“I’ll never understand you mortals,” Deena said simply. “But I’ll try your way. I’ll try sitting with you and Sorrowful in your pain, without taking it away.”

“Thank you, Deena,” Mara said.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm posting these at about the rate of once a week. I know that's very different from how I used to be, but I have a lot on my plate now. I do have the next two books mapped out, so your patience is appreciated.
>
> Mara's story continues in **Singularity: The Point of No Return**, now available!

Euology

Chapter Notes

> Mara's story continues in **Singularity: The Point of No Return**, now available!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The flattened mountaintop came to an abrupt end, and Mara approached the overhang, peering in a direction that felt like "down." Nearly a dozen other mountains crested the downward slope, before reaching a smooth line, where they became rolling hills of greenery.

Mara stooped down to get a closer look and soon the direction of the ground shifted beneath her until her feet were dangling towards blue sky and her nails clung to the tip of the mountain.

"D-Deena, please help!" Mara cried, but Deena had no use for panic. She simply watched with glazed fascination.

"Deena!" she cried and the Forest Elf shook her head.

"That's not gonna work," Deena insisted. For a frozen moment, Mara wondered if this was yet another trap: one she would never get out of.

"P-please tell me what to do," Mara said.

"You have to let go," Deena said with a shrug, looking distinctly uncomfortable.

"Let go?" Mara gasped. "Y-you can't be serious."

"Let go of your expectations," Deena said.

"I can't!" Mara cried.

"Then you'll die," Deena replied.

“If I let go, I’ll die,” Mara croaked out as tears slid up her face towards her forehead.

“Yeah, that’s true,” Deena said. “But that doesn’t mean you’ll die immediately or as a result of this action.”

Bitter grief arose within Mara as she perceived her own loss, and the ripples that would make through both this world and her own. Regret surged as she considered all the ways this could have been avoided. Her thoughts lingered on the genuine fear that came from Gideon when she was ordered to go to the Valley of the Lost.

She knew the outcome would have been different if only she had her team, if only she wasn’t alone…

Looking to Deena with her grief-stricken gaze, she forced the painful words out.

“P-promise me I’m not going to be alone when I die,” Mara said.

“I can’t make that promise,” Deena said with sorrow in her gaze. “But I can promise that I’m with you right now.”

“Even though it hurts…” Mara murmured.

“Even though it hurts,” Deena repeated with a heavy sigh. “Let go, Mara.”

At that command, Mara let loose her hold on the mountaintop. She felt her weight being pulled towards the sky. And then in the next moment, she came slamming down into the rocky mountainside.

All the wind left her lungs with a painful noise and the magical rope of her transformed sword swung into view. She grasped it with aching confusion.

“Wh-... What? How?” she panted.

“I told you to let go of your expectations,” Deena said with a playful shrug. “Come on: we’re almost there.”

Mara as She-Ra hiked easily up the crest of the mountain, staring at the landscape around her as she rested on the plateau. In the distance, the snowy mountaintops descended into warm hillsides coated in layers of greenery like snow. Those evolved into volcanic formations that rumbled and occasionally sputtered searing liquid towards the sky.

Mara was captivated by various landscapes that sat so close together, connected in a way she’d never imagined before. But her gaze trailed back to the snowy peaks as Deena fluttered down to a nearby mountaintop.

“Down here!” Deena cried and as Mara drew closer, she caught sight of a brownish structure covered in snow. It wasn’t until she approached it that her mind made sense of what she was staring at: a leviathan-like brown tail with fins at the ends and along the sides. It was covered in a thick layer of snow.

“Sorrowful?” Deena called, her hands clutching together as she stepped into the mouth of the cave. Their eyes couldn’t adjust to the darkness inside, and so Mara transformed her sword into a lamp. The dim light flickered all along a greyish-brown, serpentine form that sat curled in piles more closely resembling a series of boulders than a living creature.

“S… Sorrowful?” Deena asked, her voice hushed. “Sorrowful, wake up.”

She-Ra understood even before Mara did, as apprehension of grief twisted within her, rendering her mute.

“Sorrowful… *Sorrowful, wake up! Sorrowful!*” Deena cried.

Mara shook her head, and reached blindly for Deena’s hand.

Deena wailed and shook her hand away. “*He… he’s dead….*” Deena sobbed and Mara bit her lip, turning away as loss settled

unevenly inside of her body.

“I failed…” Mara murmured to herself. “He’s dead…”

Chapter End Notes

Mara's story continues in **Singularity: The Point of No Return**, now available!

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